CHANDRADEEP KUMAR





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CASTE MASTERS?
(L–R) Swami Prasad Maurya; Akhilesh Yadav; Keshav Prasad Maurya

SAMAJWADI PARTY

BENDING OVER BACKWARDS

The brouhaha after Swami demanded that certain verses in Tulsidas's *Ramcharitmanas*, which he called derogatory and disrespectful towards women, Dalits, tribals and backward castes, be excised.

Swami, expectedly, came under fire from BJP leaders who lambasted him for "insulting" the Hindu text with his remarks. While many in his party hurriedly distanced themselves from the remarks, one section—with the tacit support of Akhilesh—backed Swami. To strengthen the party's hold over the Other Backward Classes (OBCs), they are borrowing from the maximalist tactics adopted by the Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) in the early '90s to consolidate the vote base among the Dalits and Extremely Backward Classes (EBCs).

While Swami's line of attack has antagonised leaders in the party who come from the more privileged castes, the top SP leadership evidently smells a political opportunity. Akhilesh stated that Dalits and backwards were 'Shudras' for the saffron party. "We are non-existent for them and have no identity," he said, adding that the SP will work on the ideals of Dr Ambedkar and Dr Lohia to expand its support base in the state. The interests of Dalits and OBCs are safe with the SP, he said, adding that the BJP only uses them to serve its vested interests.

THE SP HIGH COMMAND SMELLS A POLITICAL OPPORTUNITY IN SWAMI PRASAD MAURYA'S LINE OF ATTACK OVER THE *RAMCHARITMANAS*

An SP functionary close to Akhilesh said, "We did a lot of hard work earlier but every time the BJP pulled off electoral wins riding on the Hindu-Muslim factor. This time, we will challenge them on caste lines. We are demanding a caste census and the 'Shudra' debate is helping us." It was left to deputy CM Keshav Prasad Maurya to try and pull things back by backing a caste census. "I am all for it," he said. "Neither am I nor my party is in opposition on the subject."

That the SP is aligned with Swami's strategy can be gauged from the fact that no privileged caste leader got to become national general secretary among the 14 announced in the national executive list late last month. Some leaders from the general category found their names in the 67-member national executive but only as secretaries and members, not as top-ranking general secretaries. An SP functionary also claims the party has taken a leaf out of BSP founder Kanshi Ram's politics. The slogans '*Tilak, tarazu aur talwar, inko maaro joote chaar*' and '*Brahmin, Thakur, Bania chor, baaki sab hain DS-4*' used to be raised at BSP public meetings to mobilise Dalits. DS-4 refers to the forum Dalit Shoshit Samaj Sangharsh Samiti. That strategy's success now apparently motivates the SP to unite Most Backward Castes and Dalits.

"What I said was my own opinion and I won't take it back. I am not against Lord Ram. I am against certain verses in the *Ramcharitmanas*," Swami told INDIA TODAY. "The government should take note of the line '*dhol, ganwaar, shudra, pashu, naari, sakal tadhna ke adhikari*' (drums, illiterates, backwards, Dalits, animals and women are worthy of a beating) and remove it from the book." He says we need to ensure respect for women and for over 600 Dalit sub-castes, and for that, if we have to repeal a few verses, we must. "The self-proclaimed torchbearers of religion have linked my statement with religion and hence I ask whether insulting women, backwards, Dalits is religion?" asks Swami emphatically.

The BJP, for its part, is watching cautiously; the party does not want the episode to escalate. The state BJP unit is fielding only OBC/Dalit leaders to speak on the matter. Altogether, uncharacteristically, it seems on the backfoot. ■